

Chapter 96 - Getting Close

These few sentences were really unclear in pronunciation, and Su Mo couldn't hear anyway. She only blinked, completely bewildered.

Ning Fuyi held her for a while before remembering something. She quickly let go and lowered her head to wipe away the tears from the corners of her eyes.

Thinking to herself that it was fortunate Jiuying and Hannya weren't here, otherwise she could imagine how embarrassing it would be.

"Sorry," Ning Fuyi sighed with a red nose tip, but her gaze never left Su Mo's cheek. She looked somewhat greedily. Over these thirty years, she often thought of Chu Qingqiu, but for some reason, she had never entered her dreams.

Now the familiar features appeared vividly, and the face that had become blurred in her mind was finally re-carved, gradually becoming clear.

Only the same features on Su Mo's body had less of the distant coldness that kept people at arm's length, but more of the pitiful beauty of a delicate flower with teardrops. Even so, the two didn't seem like two different people.

Just like when she first saw this graceful figure in blue clothes that day, Ning Fuyi was certain that she was Chu Qingqiu.

Su Mo, however, was quite at a loss. She lowered her eyes, not daring to look at Ning Fuyi, then raised her hands, her ten fingers like colorful butterflies: "You're not afraid?"

"Why should I be afraid?" Ning Fuyi looked at the skull flower. This flower's shape and scarlet color indeed made one's whole body turn cold, but she looked at it without any disgust, only with pity.

Actually, if this flower weren't skull-shaped, it would be extremely beautiful on Su Mo's face, like gardenias and peonies competing in beauty - a magnificent sight of red and white.

"Don't you know what this birthmark means? I have an evil body that can see filthy things¹. Even the Taoist priests on the mountain avoid me, fearing they'll be entangled by fierce ghosts," Su Mo gestured with dazzling speed for the first time. If Ning Fuyi hadn't spent several nights studying by lamplight, she probably wouldn't understand at all.

"I'm not afraid of ghosts," Ning Fuyi said gently. She pulled out a handkerchief from somewhere and bent down to patiently wipe away the remaining tears on Su Mo's face.

She wiped bit by bit, and Su Mo's wet eyes followed her wrist as it moved left and right, her fingertips unconsciously gripping the corner of the blanket.

There was actually someone in this world who truly wasn't afraid of her. Even knowing her most shameful secret, they could still treat her kindly? Su Mo's shock had already overshadowed everything else, her heart beating somewhat numbly.

For the first time, the fear she had carefully hidden was known by someone, yet it wasn't as terrible as she had imagined.

While she was lost in thought, Ning Fuyi had already put away the handkerchief and lowered her head to trim the candle wick, making the room brighter.

"Who exactly are you?" Su Mo asked again.

"I said the day before yesterday that I'm a merchant from Qi Kingdom²," Ning Fuyi replied.

Su Mo shook her head: "I mean, your name."

Name? Ning Fuyi panicked for a moment in her heart, but her face remained calm as clouds and light as wind. She leisurely opened her mouth: "My surname is Liu, Liu Dieyi³."

Su Mo bit her lip, seeming to feel this name didn't match her appearance, but still nodded.

"Sleep a bit more. It's only the hour of Zi⁴," Ning Fuyi said as she pulled up the blanket, watching Su Mo slowly lie down, then skillfully tucked in the corners of the blanket for her before turning to leave.

Su Mo wanted to call her but couldn't speak. In her urgency, she made an "ah" sound. When Ning Fuyi turned back, Su Mo's face turned completely red.

Ning Fuyi couldn't help but smile: "Don't worry, I'll be right outside the door. If any blind thing comes to disturb you again, just make a sound for me to hear, and I'll make it disappear into smoke."

Su Mo withdrew her gaze and gestured: "Talking big."

"I mean you don't need to guard me. Tonight has already caused you much trouble," she indicated again.

"I only wish you would trouble me more," Ning Fuyi said softly, then opened the door and stepped into the night.

Leaving only Su Mo, who hadn't clearly seen Ning Fuyi's lip movements, lying there with confused eyes mixed with small doubts and panic.

Miraculously, after the woman left, the terrifying dirty things that had been following her vanished without a trace. Only bright candlelight remained in the room, along with the faint smell of lamp oil smoke.

The brilliant yet dim light and shadows danced on her eyelids. Su Mo's consciousness gradually scattered, and she soon entered dreamland.

This was the first time she had slept so peacefully since her parents' death, as if sinking into warm, fragrant clouds - so comfortable she didn't want to wake up.

The next day was rainy, with no sunlight streaming through the window lattice, so nothing woke Su Mo. When she opened her eyes again, the rooster's crow had long passed, and the pattering rain filled the entire world - though of course, she couldn't hear it.

But she could clearly see the water splashes bursting on the windowsill, blooming one by one against the background of lush green tree shadows.

Su Mo suddenly thought of someone. She quickly threw off the blanket, jumped down from the bed, and pulled open the door. She was immediately greeted by the woman's bamboo-like slender and tall back. She was closing her eyes as if in meditation. Hearing the sound, she turned around.

Su Mo involuntarily stepped back, her hand uneasily supporting the door frame to make herself appear calmer.

The woman smiled at her and said "You're awake."

Su Mo nodded. She looked at the dress on Ning Fuyi's body - the black skirt's color was even darker, probably dampened by moisture. Guilt welled up in her heart. She raised her hand to pull the door wider and turned to gesture for her to come in.

Ning Fuyi had originally been standing under this eave practicing cultivation. Listening to the rain and bird calls while circulating her energy had excellent effects. She woke up refreshed and clear-minded. However, seeing Su Mo's guilty expression thinking she had toiled all night, she mischievously didn't explain.

Su Mo opened the wooden cabinet and searched for a long time, finally finding a set of clean white clothes. The dress was made of cloth, but the material was much better than what she was wearing.

"This was made by my mother before she died. I never had the heart to wear it," she gestured, then stuffed the dress into Ning Fuyi's hands. "Change into this first, be careful of catching cold."

Ning Fuyi held the soft silk without speaking. Su Mo thought she disdained these clothes as shabby, so she blushed and tried to take them back, but Ning Fuyi raised her hand to avoid her.

"Such a precious thing, you just give it to me like this?" Ning Fuyi smiled.

Su Mo's heart relaxed somewhat, but her willow brows slightly raised: "When your clothes dry, you still have to return them."

Ning Fuyi hadn't smiled as much in thirty years as she had in these three days. She turned her head to suppress her smile, said thanks, then touched her belt with her fingertips. Su Mo in front of her suddenly disappeared like a whoosh. When she looked up, she could only see the door that hadn't been closed tightly.

Ning Fuyi touched her reddened earlobes, smiling until her phoenix eyes were reduced to slits.

She quickly changed clothes. The upper garment tied into the skirt waist fit reasonably well, but the lower skirt was visibly shorter. Ning Fuyi didn't mind, arranged her hair, and went out.

Su Mo had already washed up and warmed yesterday's leftover food, adding water to the rice to make porridge, placing it on a bamboo tray to carry.

Ning Fuyi took it from her hands and went back into the room to set it on the table. Su Mo withdrew her hands, suddenly feeling a strange sensation in her heart, as if they had lived like this for many years in such a gentle, flowing way.

What nonsense am I thinking? Su Mo shook her head and sat down to eat.

"Shall we go somewhere today?" Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows, indicating this sentence was in a questioning tone.

Su Mo put down her chopsticks: "Where?"

"Qin Manor," Ning Fuyi said.

As soon as these two words were spoken, Su Mo obviously became terrified. Her hand supporting the bowl bottom weakened, and she nearly dropped the bowl. Fortunately, Ning Fuyi was quick to help her grip the bowl's rim, guiding her to slowly set it down.

"You've been seeing ghosts since childhood yet still managed to live until now. You must be used to it by now, right?" Ning Fuyi said gently. Her long eyelashes covered her pupils as she withdrew her hand and continued eating calmly.

Su Mo's hand gripping the bowl tightened, and she hummed in agreement.

She was indeed used to it. Her childhood was the most frightening time. She didn't know why she could see those strange things - writhing blood mud on the roof, bloody hands that could emerge from the ground at any time, heads hanging upside down outside the window lattice after nightfall.

Every time she saw them, she would cry and make a fuss, but her parents couldn't drive those things away for her. They could only cover her eyes and coax her not to cry anymore, lest they attract the neighbors.

When she grew older, she learned about this strange thing she was born with, called yin-yang eyes.

To prevent her from being dragged away and burned to death, her parents hardly let her go out. When it was absolutely necessary to show her face, they made her wear several layers of veils, using ugliness as an excuse to hide her appearance.

She was still afraid of those things, but as she grew day by day, she also knew this was her inescapable fate. Old people said those born with yin-yang eyes had been extremely evil people in their previous lives, having been tortured in the eighteen levels of hell⁵.

Perhaps she really had done some heinous bad deeds in her previous life, which was why she had this sin to atone for in this life. So she never complained about heaven and earth, only hoped to gather more medicine and save more people to redeem her sins, so she could be a normal person in the next life.

She had been able to suppress her fear, pretending not to see those things. Fortunately, they wouldn't come to harm her either. Apart from looking terrifyingly disgusting, they had no malice.

However, the one at Qin Manor was an exception.

"When I first came and saw you, you were fine, going up the mountain alone to gather herbs without fear. Only after entering Qin Manor did you become so frightened," Ning Fuyi swallowed the last mouthful of porridge and put down her bowl and chopsticks. "So I thought, perhaps the thing at Qin Manor is different from the others."

Among the six realms⁶, actually only the underworld was the most strange and unfathomable place. Cultivators could detect fierce ghosts with deep resentment that could manifest, but for spiritual bodies without such heavy resentment, they were like mortals - unable to see them.

At most, they could sense a few gusts of cold wind, but because their power was too small to hurt people, even their location was hard to determine.

So unless Ning Fuyi followed Su Mo around at all times to set up barriers for her, it would be difficult to block that thing's entanglement.

Su Mo didn't respond, seemingly acquiescing.

"The best way to eliminate fear is to face it. Even if I can help you get rid of it, there's no guarantee another one won't appear. Your spirit is already like a bowstring about to snap. I'm afraid if this happens a few more times, you'll..."

"If you trust me, I will definitely protect you completely and won't let it harm you. However, this method ultimately depends on you. If you're unwilling, I also have ways to prevent it from coming again," Ning Fuyi said calmly and seriously.

Su Mo couldn't hear the tone of the words and could only stare intently at the person's face while they spoke. The woman's phoenix eyes were long and narrow, originally not very approachable, but when she looked at her like this while speaking, she could always read gentleness from those eyes.

As if possessed by ghosts and spirits, Su Mo nodded.

Ning Fuyi pressed her lips into a smile and pointed to her half-remaining bowl: "Then after you finish eating, we'll go."

This time, taking Su Mo along meant they couldn't fly. Ning Fuyi had to walk with her, so by the time they saw the town, it was almost noon.

The continuous drizzle kept falling without pause. The ground was all muddy - after walking two steps, shoes would sink into the mud. But the grass had been washed to a tender green color, with fragrance rushing to their faces.

Ning Fuyi held an umbrella and walked alone, watching Su Mo in her straw raincoat ahead.

Su Mo was still very unwilling to get close to people. Her original intention was for them to share one umbrella, but Su Mo had refused. Ning Fuyi wasn't disappointed and leisurely followed behind.

Ice that had been frozen on the mountaintop for a long time was extremely difficult to thaw. Ning Fuyi had already seen this thoroughly from Chu Qingqiu.

The town also had few pedestrians on rainy days. The stone slabs were washed clean enough to reflect the green trees and eaves on both sides. When they were almost at Qin Manor, the drizzle gradually stopped.

Ning Fuyi put away her umbrella and watched Su Mo take off her straw raincoat. The veil still covered her face, leaving only her beautiful peach blossom eyes visible.

The main gate, wet from rain, was even more scarlet like blood, as if touching it would stain one's hands with gore. Ning Fuyi used her umbrella handle to push open the door. The door wasn't locked and opened with a creak.

Su Mo tugged at her sleeve and gestured: "Don't we need to ask Young Master Qin?"

Young Master Qin? She called him quite intimately. Ning Fuyi bit her lip and hummed lowly.

"No need. If he dares to block me, I'll break his legs," Ning Fuyi said stiffly, lifting her leg to step over the threshold.

Qin Manor was no different from the previous day, just appearing more sinister due to the overcast sky. Moss and wind-carved traces covered the residence, desolate and bleak.

"Where is the thing you see?" Ning Fuyi stood in the center of the courtyard and asked.

Su Mo was obviously starting to tremble. Though she resisted greatly, her body still unconsciously moved closer to Ning Fuyi, closing her eyes and clenching her clothes.

This courtyard was like a nightmare to her. Only by staying close to the woman beside her could the terror in her heart lessen somewhat.

Ning Fuyi felt her approach, her gaze becoming flustered for a moment. She closed her eyes and used her divine sense to search for the source of ghostly energy. Just as she detected a trace of the sinister, she heard a hoarse scream from beside her.

Ning Fuyi quickly turned around, but Su Mo had already rushed into her embrace in panic, those hands full of scars desperately gripping her clothing, trembling as she hid her face in her chest.

Author's Note:

Yiyi's inner thoughts: Pursuing a wife in the mortal world is much easier than on the mountain!

Footnotes

1. **Filthy things (秽物)** - In Chinese supernatural beliefs, refers to unclean spiritual entities like ghosts, evil spirits, or demons
2. **Qi Kingdom (岐国)** - A fictional kingdom name in the story
3. **Liu Dieyi (柳蝶衣)** - The false name Ning Fuyi gives, meaning "Willow Butterfly Clothes"
4. **Hour of Zi (子时)** - Traditional Chinese time period, approximately 11 PM to 1 AM
5. **Eighteen levels of hell (十八层地狱)** - In Chinese Buddhist and folk religion, refers to the multiple levels of hell where different punishments are administered based on one's sins
6. **Six realms (六界)** - The six domains of existence in this cultivation world: Heaven, Asura, Human, Animal, Hungry Ghost, and Hell realms